

THE FOREIGN OFFICE AND THE 'EDUCATION' OF PUBLIC OPINION BEFORE THE FIRST WORLD WAR

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On 30 November 1912 Sir Arthur Nicolson, permanent under-secretary at the Foreign Office, wrote a letter concerning Austro-Russian rivalry in the Balkans which had it been undated might well have been assigned to the month of July 1914:

If Austria attempts any coercive measures of any kind against Serbia I am quite convinced... that Russia would immediately take action herself. The question then arises as to what part Germany would play in the event of Austria and Russia coming to blows... and ... I myself have little doubt that Germany would stand by the side of Austria. I am informed by military experts that the Austrian Army could not really cope successfully with the Russian, and it is perfectly evident that Germany would not stand idly by and see her Ally defeated.

If Germany then is compelled to side with Austria, France, by her Treaty, will be compelled to cooperate with Russia. Then comes another problem, and that is the attitude we ourselves should pursue.¹

Eight days after this was written, at a conference in Berlin with Admirals von Tirpitz, von Muller, von Heeringen and General von Moltke, the Kaiser envisaged the same sequence of events: Austria attacking Serbia, Russia intervening by moving into Galicia, and Germany finding herself at war with Russia, France and England. The most concrete of the decisions taken at that conference was the adoption of a suggestion made by the Kaiser, namely that the press be used 'to prepare the popularity of a war against Russia'. Immediately after the meeting, Muller wrote to Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg, telling him that it had been agreed

to enlighten the people through the press of the great national interests, which would be at stake also for Germany, if a war were to break out over the Austro-Serbian conflict... The people must not be in a position of asking themselves only at the outbreak of a great European war, what are the interests that Germany would be fighting for. The people ought rather to be accustomed to the idea of such a war beforehand.²

According to Professor Fischer, the indications are that such a campaign of 'enlightenment' began without delay in Germany. The editor since 1906 of the liberal *Berliner Tageblatt* met Bethmann-Hollweg for the first time, by invitation, in January 1913, and was greatly struck by his insistence on the Russian menace and the consequence of the Balkan Wars.³ 'Attack from the Slavs' was the 'effective slogan' chosen for the campaign.⁴

That there was not even any call from the British Foreign Office for any measures designed to warn the British public that it might find itself involved in a European

¹ Nicolson to Rodd 30 Nov. 1912, Carnock MSS, Public Record Office, F.O. 800/360.

² J. C. C. Rohl, 'Admiral von Muller and the approach of war, 1911–14', *Historical Journal*, xii, 4 (1969), 661–4. ³ Theodor Wolff, *The eve of 1914* (London, 1935), pp. 355–7.

⁴ F. Fischer, *War of illusions* (New York, 1975), pp. 172, 190–9, 207.

war originating in a dispute between Austria and Serbia, and to explain and justify such involvement, is all the more striking when certain other points are considered. Although it was widely felt in British diplomatic circles after the first Balkan War that, in Cartwright's words, 'Serbia will some day set Europe by the ears',⁵ this was not the first time the sequence of events set down by Nicolson had been envisaged. Exactly four years earlier Nicolson's predecessor, Sir Charles Hardinge, had had to face enquiries from the Russian ambassador as to what the British attitude would be on the hypothesis – which Hardinge considered all too real – of Austria supported by Germany fighting the small Slav states and thus dragging Russia and France into the conflict.⁶ Hardinge himself wrote in March 1909:

The Austrians are confident that Germany will keep Russia quiet, and I think this is fairly certain, unless Pan-Slavist opinion in Russia were suddenly to be aroused to such an extent that the Government would not be able to restrain it. If the Russian Government went to war Germany would stand by, unless Austria were getting the worst of it. In that case Germany would intervene to wrest the victory from Russia, and this would mean a general European conflagration.⁷

Moreover, throughout the years of peace the Foreign Office regularly complained of the public's supreme indifference towards and ignorance of foreign affairs. Nicolson, then ambassador in St Petersburg, did not demur when during the crisis over the annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina the journalist Valentine Chirol wrote to him: 'in general, people are, I think, sick to death in this country of the Near Eastern crisis, for few of them understand it and still fewer, of course, realise that behind it lies the much bigger question of the balance of power in Europe'.⁸ Shortly after this Hardinge commented that 'public opinion in England has not as yet grasped the danger to Europe of Germany's ambitious designs'.⁹ Two years later the ambassador to Berlin was still distressed 'to think that there are so many people in England who do not realise what our position would be should the Triple Entente come to grief and Germany obtain the hegemony of Europe'.¹⁰ Nicolson agreed:

So many people regard the maintenance of the equilibrium of Europe as merely an abstract principle, for the support of which it is not worth firing a shot, and they do not understand that were the Triple Entente broken up we should be isolated and compelled to do the bidding of the Power which assumed the hegemony of Europe.¹¹

Following the Agadir crisis Mallet wrote that although the firmness displayed by England had saved the situation in Europe, 'England is the only country where this is not properly understood'.¹² In April 1914 Nicolson was still aware that 'this country has not yet sufficient knowledge to appreciate the very great importance that Russia's friendship is [sic] to us, and the dilemma in which we should be placed were she to turn her back on us'.¹³

⁵ Cartwright to Nicolson 31 Jan. 1913, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/363; Goschen to Nicolson late Jan. 1913, *ibid.*; Granville to Nicolson 13 Sept. 1912, *ibid.*/358; Paget to Nicolson 26 Nov. 1912, *ibid.*/360.

⁶ Hardinge to Goschen 3 Nov., to Nicolson 11 Nov. 1908, Hardinge MSS, Cambridge University Library, vol. 13. ⁷ Hardinge to Bryce 26 Mar. 1909, *ibid.* vol. 17.

⁸ Chirol to Nicolson 19 Jan. 1909, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/342.

⁹ Hardinge memo 4 May 1909, G. P. Gooch and H. W. V. Temperley, *British documents on the origins of the War 1898–1914* (11 vols. London, 1926–38), v, Appendix III.

¹⁰ Goschen to Nicolson 3 Mar. 1911, Public Record Office, F.O. 371/1123/11853.

¹¹ Nicolson to Goschen 28 Feb. 1911, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/347.

¹² Mallet to Bryce 22 Dec. 1911, Bryce MSS, Bodleian Library Oxford, USA vol. 32.

¹³ Nicolson to Mallet 27 Apr. 1914, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/373.

If any appeals were made by the Foreign Office for efforts to remedy the state of affairs of which they complained, and to educate public opinion on to what they considered to be right lines, these have not survived. It is true that, at the turn of 1911 Sanderson, believing that Grey's foreign policy would be better received if more information were provided, suggested that more Blue Books be produced, and that Hardinge, with whom he corresponded over this, agreed that it certainly ought to be done.¹⁴ But Sanderson had retired as permanent under-secretary nearly six years previously, and Hardinge was at the time viceroy of India. It is also true that Mallet encouraged the publication of a letter by Balfour on the international situation; and that some diplomats, such as Spring-Rice, were able to supply information to certain journals and to comment upon draft articles submitted to them.¹⁵ Such sporadic efforts were token in the extreme. Sanderson's concern for Blue Books and Hardinge's explanation of Grey's unpopularity in terms of his not spending enough time discussing current affairs 'with politicians of both Houses' indicate the narrowness of their conception of 'public opinion'. A. J. Balfour's letter was directed at the German public, and Mallet was not convinced that it would do much good: 'I do not think that a few isolated attempts of this kind will have much effect, as the German Government have been purposely misleading the [German] public for many years past.' In Mallet's opinion, it was 'even *more* important to educate public opinion *here*, in order that the Government of the day may have the necessary backing when the next crisis occurs'.¹⁶ Yet it was precisely this which neither Mallet himself nor, so far as can be seen, anyone else within the Foreign Office consistently called for; it was precisely this which there was no sustained bid to undertake.

On the contrary, the prevailing ignorance was positively fostered, even within the horizons bounded by Westminster. When drafting an answer to a parliamentary question on the progress of the Anglo-German negotiations for a reduction in naval expenditure Sir Eyre Crowe included the sentence: 'It would not be in the public interest to lay papers.'¹⁷ He was later reported by the French chargé d'affaires as having said 'qu'il déplorait tous les discours publics concernant les affaires étrangères'.¹⁸ Sir Edward Grey evaded Noel Buxton's and Swift Macneill's demands for the appointment of a committee on foreign relations in 1913.¹⁹ So far as the general public was concerned, no consideration was given by the Foreign Office to the setting up of a press bureau on the continental model. Sir Francis Bertie wrote from Paris in 1911 that the 'Bureau de la Presse' at the ministry of foreign affairs had been re-organized in recent years 'with the object of enabling the Ministry to induce the press, or at any rate, the chief organs which wrote with authority on foreign affairs, to present a unanimous front in any crisis of foreign policy'. This had been successfully done during the Casablanca crisis of 1908, and this success was expected to be repeated in the current crisis over Agadir. There was no indication here, nor in de Salis' earlier report that the German Press Bureau had been divided into two sections, one for home and one for foreign affairs, that Great

¹⁴ Sanderson to Hardinge 15 Dec. 1911, 26 Jan. 1912; Hardinge to Sanderson 12 Feb. 1912, Hardinge MSS, vol. 92.

¹⁵ Mallet to Short 4 May 1912, Balfour MSS, British Library, Add. MSS 49747; S. Gwynn (ed.), *The letters and friendships of Sir Cecil Spring-Rice* (2 vols. London, 1929), II, 144; Hardinge to Maxse 16 Oct. 1901, Maxse MSS, West Sussex County Record Office.

¹⁶ My italics.

¹⁷ F.O. 371/1123/5379, 7 Feb. 1911.

¹⁸ Fleuriau to Pichon 21 Oct. 1913, *Documents Diplomatiques Français 1870-1914* (Paris 1929-62), 3rd series, VIII, no. 367.

¹⁹ *Hansard*, fifth ser. LIII, 401-7, 455-7, 29 May 1913.

Britain might suffer from her lack of a similar institution.²⁰ As for the foreign secretary, his view was simply that 'A Press Bureau is used to make mischief'.²¹ There was no appreciation that such an organization might be used for good as effectively as it was acknowledged by the Foreign Office that the Germans had used it, on both their own and on British public opinion, in what was considered to be the opposite direction.²²

So far as the Foreign Office was concerned, if the press was ever 'inspired', it was not they who were responsible. At the beginning of his foreign secretaryship Grey took it that 'The Press is entirely outside our control', and he continued to maintain that this was the case.²³ It is most unlikely that the Foreign Office ever issued any such *mot d'ordre* to the press as Mensdorff, the Austrian ambassador, at one point suspected.²⁴ Crowe wrote to Cartwright in June 1910: 'Is not on the whole our policy of leaving newspapers severely alone the best, if not the only sound one?'²⁵ Grey wrote to him shortly afterwards regarding the possibility of a press war: 'I quite agree it is not desirable that *The Times* should work up a controversy with the Austrian Press... I have expressed this view to Chirol, but I cannot go further in attempting to control the Press here'.²⁶ Intervention was overwhelmingly of a negative character. An editor might occasionally be asked to delay publication of a certain article, or to moderate a certain line. In October 1908 the editor of the *Daily Mail* was dissuaded from publishing an interview with the Kaiser.²⁷ At the outset of the

²⁰ De Salis to Grey 27 Oct. 1908, Bertie to Grey 6 July 1911, Gooch and Temperley, vi, no. 103, vii, no. 361. As a matter of fact Britain was to suffer almost immediately. The Agadir crisis was not marked by the development of a unanimous view by the press. The *Westminster Gazette* at first defended the German action (*The history of The Times*, 5 vols. London 1947, iii, 699). The *Daily Graphic* continued to do so (F.O. 371/1163/28274). The *Economist* failed to recognize that there was any crisis or anything of which to disapprove until Lloyd George spoke at the Mansion House on 21 July. It then disapproved of the speech (*Economist* 8, 29 July 1911). Lloyd George intervened to try to change the pacific line of the *Manchester Guardian*, but could not overcome the efforts made by Loreburn, the Lord Chancellor, in the opposite direction (T. Wilson, *The political diaries of C. P. Scott 1911-28*, London 1970, p. 46; W. S. Blunt, *My diaries*, 2 vols. London 1920, ii, 373-4). In case the German government was reading the wrong papers Grey encouraged the chief whip, Elibank, to publish in *The Times* on 29 July the findings of researches amongst the radical M.P.s which were interpreted as showing that any impression the Germans might have that there were two separate wings of opinion in the cabinet and that the old Boer War differences still existed in the ranks of the Liberal party was erroneous (Grey note 31 July 1911, Grey MSS, P.R.O., F.O. 800/93). On the French and German press bureaux see P. G. Lauren, *Diplomats and bureaucrats* (Stanford, 1976).

²¹ Grey to Rodd 13 Jan. 1913, in G. M. Trevelyan, *Grey of Fallodon* (London, 1937), p. 219.

²² Crowe minute 29 Apr. 1912, F.O. 371/1371/17863: 'The German govt is conveying through the Liberal Press to the British public what the former wants the latter to believe its policy is. I do not think these efforts to influence British public opinion remain so fruitless as Lord Morley seems disposed to believe.' Crowe thought that some of Grey's parliamentary critics were 'clearly being used by that part of the organisation of the German Foreign Office which exists for the purpose of disseminating in England an entirely erroneous view of the history of Anglo-German relations and of influencing English public opinion in favour of this country making gratuitous concessions to Germany': Crowe minutes 23 Jan. 1913, *ibid.*/1372/2802; 10 Dec. 1911, *ibid.*/1128/49252.

²³ Grey to Lascelles 2 Jan. 1906, 22 Feb. 1908, Grey MSS, F.O. 800/61.

²⁴ F. R. Bridge, *Great Britain and Austria-Hungary 1906-14* (London, 1972), p. 30.

²⁵ F.O. 371/827/22901.

²⁶ Grey to Cartwright 5 July 1910, Grey MSS, F.O. 800/41.

²⁷ M. V. Brett and Esher (eds.), *Letters and journals of Reginald, Viscount Esher* (4 vols. London, 1934-8), ii, 362; Hardinge to Lascelles 2 Oct. 1907, Grey MSS, F.O. 800/61.

Tripoli War a bid was made, with some success, to encourage 'the more reasonable editors' to take a more neutral attitude.²⁸ The main concern of this type of intervention, however, was lest foreign Powers like Germany and Italy be offended or alienated, rather than with persuading the British people of the unwisdom of offending or alienating them. As when Hardinge had written to his close friend and confidant on *The Times* about the importance of that journal's having a permanent correspondent in St Petersburg, for 'in order to arrive at a friendly understanding with Russia it is necessary to lose no time in preparing public opinion for it', clearly meaning public opinion *in Russia*²⁹, it was as if the English papers were for the eyes of foreigners only.

Despite the example set by the Germans of what might be achieved in the way of moulding public opinion, to which the minutes of Crowe bear the most eloquent testimony; despite the presence for over four years as permanent under-secretary of a man whose awareness of the value of publicity in certain contexts was shown by his writing, of proposals for Macedonian reform: 'Publicity is the only way by which to wheel the Powers into line... Educate public opinion here in Europe which can then force the Governments into a more humanitarian frame of mind...';³⁰ despite the established and anticipated benefits from the Foreign Office's point of view of an 'educated' public opinion,³¹ the Foreign Office appears to have been prepared to leave the public to find its own way, to mature in its own time.

This was not only because the Foreign Office were even more reluctant demagogues than they were democrats. Nor was it only because they had no wish to reproduce in their own country any features of imperial Germany. Nor was it even because the existing state of affairs had certain advantages – though it had. Of the French Bureau des Communications Hardinge wrote: 'its disadvantage is that it becomes difficult to know the state of public opinion on foreign affairs, since the line to be taken and suggested by the Minister for Foreign Affairs must have a natural tendency to suppress or modify a free expression of public opinion'.³² The absence of such intermediary agencies enabled the Foreign Office to use public opinion more legitimately than they felt other nations, and particularly Germany, could do, as an excuse for taking – or, more often, not taking – certain action.³³ Again, leaving the public in an uninformed state spared the Foreign Office the embarrassing and no doubt thankless task of revealing what British foreign policy was, what it was based on, and what consequences it might entail. It was the response at home that had caused Lord Selborne to say to the cabinet in November 1901 that his recommended application of the Two Power Standard was not one that

²⁸ Gooch and Temperley, ix (i), nos. 256, 264, 267.

²⁹ Hardinge to Chirol 3 June 1904, Sanderson MSS, P.R.O., F.O. 800/2.

³⁰ Hardinge to Goschen 7 Apr. 1908, Hardinge MSS, vol. 13.

³¹ Mallet to Bertie 2 June 1904, Bertie MSS, P.R.O., F.O. 800/170: 'The only terms on which I would make a treaty with (Germany) would be an understanding on their part to add no more to their fleet. If the Govt. doesn't understand this, the Country does and I believe public opinion will keep them straight'.

³² Hardinge minute 26 Jan. 1909, F.O. 371/666/3379.

³³ Crowe minute 17 Mar. 1914, *ibid.*/2092/11538: 'No German Government... will be drawn into a war by popular clamour. On the contrary, popular clamour will be engineered by the German Government if it wishes to go to war.' During the Agadir crisis Grey maintained that 'a repetition of 1870, when France was manoeuvred into making war against Germany, would be a fatal mistake as regards public opinion here': Grey to Nicolson 13 Sept. 1911, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/350.

could be publicly stated: 'an avowedly lower standard would be misunderstood and denounced... In Parliament I would always speak, in general terms, of not falling below the Two Power Standard. To the Cabinet I would suggest such provision as to make reasonable the certainty of success against France and Russia.'³⁴ It was not just from the Turks that British weakness at the Straits was being kept a secret.³⁵ Publicity for the fact that Britain associated herself with France and Russia because she was, in Nicolson's words, 'not strong enough to stand alone' would have engendered resentment, rather than support.³⁶ The reaction of the French and Russians may be imagined. To have been explicit about Germany would certainly have exacerbated relations and might even have provoked her to war. And when Sir Edward Grey suggested that he might consult M.P.s in the lobbies as to how they felt about going to war with France against Germany if the Algeiras Conference broke down it was not only at the novelty and unorthodoxy of the approach that his private secretary was 'secretly horrified'.³⁷ There was an element of fear at the revelation of such a possibility, and at the necessity of defending it in advance of the contingency arising. There was something to be said, sometimes, for not giving certain sections of the public anything with which to disagree.

Even added together, these factors and attitudes do not fully account for the phenomenon. In particular, they do not account for the attitude of Sir Arthur Nicolson, as embodied in a letter to Buchanan of 3 December 1912:

There is of course little or no interest here in respect especially of the question of Serbian access to the Adriatic, but if a general European war did ensue I can hardly imagine that the British public would allow us to stand idly by and watch with equanimity the defeat of possibly one of our own friends.³⁸

No doubt the habit of authority on the part of those who liked to see themselves as the makers of policy, and their reliance upon a deferential attitude towards them on the part of the public were both present in greater force than they were to be after 1917. But the basis of Nicolson's confidence was of another order. It was a compound of assumptions and of expectations founded on precedent. This compound enabled the Foreign Office to consider certain views, however vocally expressed, as unrepresentative; its existence also accounts for why the Foreign Office felt no overriding need to educate public opinion, why the ignorance of the latter was not entirely unacceptable, and why the lack of means with which to consult public opinion was not more severely felt. Over a certain range of issues, the Foreign Office believed, and had from past experience good reason to believe,³⁹ that the nation

³⁴ Selborne memo 16 Nov. 1901, P.R.O., CAB 37/59/118.

³⁵ Committee of Imperial Defence, minutes of 96th meeting, 28 Feb. 1907, P.R.O., CAB 2/2/1.

³⁶ Nicolson to Goschen 28 Feb. 1911, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/347; see O. J. Hale, *Publicity and diplomacy* (New York 1940), p. 393.

³⁷ Mallet to Bertie 11 Jan. 1906, Bertie MSS, F.O. 800/164.

³⁸ Nicolson to Buchanan 3 Dec. 1912, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/360.

³⁹ In November 1911 Grey had agreed with Cambon's picture: 'British public opinion... had an instinctive mistrust and dislike of an aggressive and bullying Power. All British history proved this.' Gooch and Temperley, vii, no. 617. Nicolson wrote to Hardinge on 14 September 1911 that the pro-German views of the king's private secretary, Bigge, had been modified by the Agadir crisis (Hardinge MSS, vol. 92); the germanophile John Burns had reacted to the first of the Moroccan crises by telling an agent of the German government: 'Look here, sir, you Germans must mend your manners, or you'll find the Baltic black with our ships and we'll wipe the floor with your Emperor' (Hardinge to Lascelles 26 Feb. 1906, Lascelles MSS, P.R.O., F.O. 800/13).

thought, or would think, in a certain way. Public opinion was the answer the advisers were sure the nation would give to certain questions, if asked. This being the case, there was no need actually to ask the questions. Within this range were issues on which the advisers were convinced that the public would share their opinion. To this extent, there was no need to provide the answers. On some questions, Foreign Office opinion was convinced it was public opinion.

One of the areas where the attitude of the public could be forecast with some confidence concerned a Russian descent upon Constantinople.⁴⁰ Another area, where the public's attitude could be both forecast and approved of by the advisers, concerned the independence and integrity of Belgium. In the scenarios envisaged in 1908/9 and in 1912/13 it was clear that any war that began in the east would work its way west. As it was acknowledged that Belgium was the 'highway to France' it was only a matter of time before Belgium became involved.⁴¹ A war over Serbia, as Cartwright realized, would be unpopular in England.⁴² A war over Belgium would not be. Clemenceau in August 1908 recalled a conversation in which Grey had said that if the Germans entered and overran Belgium 'it would make a great stir in England'.⁴³ Hence Grey's assurances, according to Paul Cambon, that whilst the attitude of the cabinet could not be guaranteed, public opinion would pronounce itself in favour of France and would determine the direction taken by the British Government.⁴⁴ And hence Nicolson's readiness to tell the French ambassador in December 1912 that, if all the continental powers were involved with one another,

l'opinion n'hésiterait pas à se prononcer pour une intervention immédiate. A la Chambre des Communes où l'a soucie peu du différend austro-serbe, où même un conflit limité à l'Allemagne, l'Autriche-Hongrie et la Russie ne rencontrerait que l'indifférence, il paraît certain que l'entrée en jeu de la France déterminerait une poussée dans le sens de l'intervention.⁴⁵

Another example of the missing link was provided by Hardinge in November 1908:

In the event of Germany provoking hostilities with France, the question of armed intervention by Great Britain is one which would have to be decided by the Cabinet; but the decision would be more easily arrived at if German aggression had entailed a violation of the neutrality of Belgium which Great Britain has guaranteed to maintain.⁴⁶

⁴⁰ Paget to Salisbury 10 Feb. 1887, Salisbury papers, Hatfield House, A/48; Deym to Kalnoky 14 June 1893, in H. W. V. Temperley and L. M. Penson, *Foundations of British foreign policy 1792-1902* (Cambridge 1938), p. 474; Sanderson to Grey 3 Mar. 1906, Grey MSS, F.O. 800/111; Hardinge to Bertie 12 Oct. 1908, Hardinge MSS, vol. 13.

⁴¹ Goschen to Grey 29 Aug. 1908, Gooch and Temperley, vi, no. 100; J. Pope-Hennessy, *Lord Crewe* (London, 1955), p. 144; Lloyd George to Churchill 13 Sept. 1911, in R. S. Churchill, *W. S. Churchill* (London, 1969), companion vol. 2, part 2, pp. 1125-6.

⁴² Cartwright to Nicolson 14 Mar. 1913, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/364.

⁴³ Wickham Steed memo of conversation with Clemenceau 19 Aug. 1908, published in *The Times*, 24 Dec. 1920; and see Lansdowne MSS, P.R.O., F.O. 800/130.

⁴⁴ P. Cambon to Pichon 18 Nov. 1908, *D.D.F.* 2nd series, xi, no. 558.

⁴⁵ P. Cambon to Poincaré 4 Dec. 1912, *ibid.* 3rd series, iv, no. 622. Bertie was of the same opinion: M. Paléologue, *Journal de 1913 et 1914* (Paris, 1947), p. 28.

⁴⁶ Hardinge memo 11 Nov. 1908, Grey MSS, F.O. 800/92. Though this was presented to the C.I.D. sub-committee on the Military Needs of the Empire in December 1908, it, and a memo by Crowe of 15 November 1908 on Britain's obligation to defend Belgian neutrality (Gooch and Temperley, vii, no. 311), may have been not absolutely unconnected with the crisis in Franco-German relations which was then at its height.

In the event, these forecasts proved accurate, this confidence not misplaced. Just as the German chancellor waited upon the declaration of Russian general mobilization in order to take advantage of its impact upon a public which had been prepared to regard Russia in the worst possible light,⁴⁷ so Sir Edward Grey, whose initial response, according to his parliamentary private secretary, was that 'we cannot possibly afford to see the position of France weakened'⁴⁸, and who at the same time appreciated that public opinion would not sanction going to war in the Serbian quarrel,⁴⁹ waited upon a German invasion of Belgium in order to benefit from the predictable but untutored reaction of the British. C. P. Scott observed in the *Manchester Guardian* on 30 July 1914 that Grey 'walks deliberately past opportunities of saying that we are and will be neutral in the quarrels of Europe'. Though Grey hinted to the German ambassador as early as 27 July that Britain would not remain neutral if France and Russia became involved in the war,⁵⁰ matters had not then progressed far enough for this to be announced publicly. Four days later Grey explained, according to Paul Cambon, what was still missing:

L'opinion publique en Angleterre et l'état d'esprit actuel du Parlement ne permettent pas au Gouvernement de prendre dès à présent un engagement formel.

Among the things necessary to bring about 'une modification dans la situation'; among the 'other issues' which Grey had told Lichnowsky 'would supersede the dispute between Austria and Serbia' was – the question of Belgian neutrality.⁵¹ Grey told Lichnowsky on 1 August that 'the neutrality of Belgium would appeal very strongly to public opinion here', and it is difficult not to agree with Outhwaite M.P., that the appeal made to the house of commons on 3 August on behalf of Belgium was 'an appeal that Grey knew would carry weight in this country'.⁵² Belgium was being used as a *locus standi*, whose value was, as Grey had said of a proposed exchange of assurances between England and France concerning their possessions in the

⁴⁷ Fischer, pp. 197, 494, 498, 511.

⁴⁸ A. Murray, *Master and Brother* (London, 1945), pp. 116–17. Murray places this immediately after the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand. As the Foreign Office did not expect Sarajevo to have serious political consequences outside Austria-Hungary (Nicolson to de Bunsen 6 July, to Buchanan 30 June 1914, Carnock MSS, F.O. 800/375, /374) it is more likely that it followed the Austrian ultimatum to Serbia. Masterman recalled Grey in the week before war murmuring to himself: 'We can't desert France' (Lucy Masterman, *C. F. G. Masterman*, London, 1939, p. 265). See H. Butterfield, 'Sir Edward Grey in July 1914', *Historical Studies*, v (1965), 1–25.

⁴⁹ Grey to Buchanan 25 July 1914, Gooch and Temperley, xi, no. 112.

⁵⁰ I. Geiss, *July 1914* (London, 1967), docs. 97–9; K. Jarausch, 'The illusion of limited war: Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg's calculated risk, July 1914', *Central European History*, II (1969), 65.

⁵¹ P. Cambon to Viviani, 31 July 1914, *D.D.F.*, 3rd series, xi, nos. 445, 459; Grey to Goschen 27 July 1914, Gooch and Temperley, xi, no. 176.

⁵² *Ibid.* no. 448; *Hansard*, fifth ser. LXV, 1861. See also Churchill to Ponsonby 27 July 1914, R. S. Churchill, companion vol. 2, part 3, p. 1991; Churchill note 1 Aug. 1914: 'Public opinion might veer round at any moment if Belgium is invaded and we must be ready to meet this opinion', *ibid.* p. 1996; Bryce to C. P. Scott 31 July 1914: 'The Germans, I hear, are already considering whether they had not better take this chance and violate Belgian neutrality and it is possible that if they felt sure that England would not stir they might do this – a result much to be deprecated, for it might turn public opinion here towards war' (Bryce MSS, E 31); on 2 August Ramsay MacDonald agreed that if Belgian neutrality were infringed, England would be justified in declaring war upon Germany (Lord Riddell, *War Diary* (London, 1933), p. 4).

Mediterranean and the Atlantic, that it 'makes it easier for us to put our case before the public'.⁵³

The knowledge that there were such appeals, the anticipation of the reaction to such appeals, and the conviction that if they were made at the right time and under the right circumstances they would be effective, account largely for what might otherwise be considered a reprehensible lapse if not quite a dereliction of duty on the part of those responsible for the conduct of British foreign policy.

⁵³ Grey minute 29 Apr. 1907, F.O. 371/364/13755. Crowe's memo of 15 November 1908 was printed for the cabinet in September 1911, when the possibility of Belgium's becoming involved could not be ruled out: P.R.O., ADM 116/3486.